2/1 GAME FORCING · AN OPTION ON THE 5-CARD MAJOR, STRONG NT SYSTEM

Option · 13 Nov 2026

Over 1♥/1♠: 1NT is forcing (6-12) and a new suit at the 2-level forces to game (13+). Over 1♦, 2♣ is game forcing too. Everything not shown here is as on the strong NT chart. Points are HCP.

1 WHAT 2/1 CHANGES

2/1 game forcing is an option on the strong NT chart. **Everything else stays**: openings, 1NT and its responses, raises with 4+ trumps (Bergen 3♣/3♦, Jacoby 2NT, splinters), RKCB and control bids.

Only two things change:
① Over 1♥/1♠, **1NT is forcing** for one round (6-12, fewer than 3 trumps).
② A **new suit at the 2-level** (1♥–2♣/2♦, 1♠–2♣/2♦/2♥, and 1♦–2♣) is **game forcing, 13+**.

Why play it? Once a 2-over-1 has set up game, neither of you has to jump to show strength. You can bid slowly and naturally, find the right game, and look for slam with plenty of room.

2 RESPONDING TO 1♥/1♠

Partner opens **1♥** or **1♠**

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4+ trumps

As the chart: 2M up to 6 · 3♦ 7-9 · 3♣ 10-12 · 2NT Jacoby 13+ · splinter · 4M weak.

3 trumps

2M 6-9 · 3M 10-12 · 3NT 13-15 balanced · 13+: **2-over-1 first**, then support.

0-2 trumps

1♠ over 1♥ with 4+ ♠ (6+) · **6-12: 1NT forcing** · **13+: new suit at the 2-level (GF)**.

With 6-12 and a long suit of your own, bid **1NT first** and show the suit next (to play with 6-9, a jump with 10-12). A 2-level new suit would promise game.

5 OVER 1♦: 2♣ IS GAME FORCING

Partner opens **1♦**

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2♣ = 13+, game forcing (5+ clubs). With less and no major: 1NT (6-10, also an unbalanced 11-12), 2NT (11-12 balanced), 3NT (13-15 balanced) as the chart. A 4-card major is still bid at the 1-level first.

Opener then bids naturally, as after any 2-over-1 (panel 4).

3 1M – 1NT FORCING

1M – **1NT forcing** (6-12)

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Opener must not pass:
• 6-card major: **2M** (11-15) · **3M** (16-18)
• a second 4+ suit below your major: **bid it** (2♣, 2♦, or 2♥ after 1♠)
• reverse (2♠ after 1♥): 16+
• 19+: jump shift with a second suit, else 4M with six
• balanced 18-19: **2NT** · 20+: **3NT**
• nothing else: **your longer minor**, even with only three (3-3: 2♣)

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Responder, 6-9: pass a minor with 5+ (4+ of 2♥) · **2M with two** (his minor may be three) · own six-card suit at the 2-level, to play.
Responder, 10-12 (invitational): raise his new suit to 3 · 3 of your own six-card suit · else **2NT**.
After 2M: 11-12 with two trumps: 3M, else pass. **After 3M:** 8+ game. **After 2NT:** 7+ 3NT.

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Opener after an invitation: 14+ accept (4M with a major fit, else 3NT) · or 4M with ≤6 losers · else pass.

4 AFTER A 2-OVER-1 (GAME FORCING)

1M – **2x** (13+, **game forcing**)

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Opener bids naturally, no jumps:
• 11-14: raise his minor with 4 (2♥ with 3) · rebid a 6-card major · else a 4-card side suit (**no barrier** once game is forced) · else raise his minor with 3 · 2NT balanced
• 15-19: show your shape · 18-19 balanced: 3NT

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Responder: 4M with 3-card support (2 opposite six) · **go slow** with extras (3M, even over his new suit, or raise his minor to 3; side suits come later as controls); a jump to game = minimum · **no fit yet: show a 2nd 5+ suit before 3NT** (only below it) · 3NT with the unbid suit stopped, no void · minor fit: a stopper in an **unbid** suit (opener 3NT, or back to the minor → 5m).
Slam: a fit and 12 tricks on losers → RKCB or control bids.

6 EXAMPLES

① 1NT forcing, then opener's three-card minor

Responder ♠52 ♥K84 ♦Q976 ♣K652 (8). Opener ♠AQJ84 ♥A62 ♦K4 ♣J73 (14).

Opener	Responder
1♠	1NT
2♣	2♠
Pass	

Opener can't pass 1NT and has no second suit, so he bids his longer minor, 2♣, with only three. Responder prefers the known five-card suit with two: 2♠.

② 1NT first, then the long suit

Responder ♠7 ♥Q4 ♦KJ9853 ♣Q962 (8). Opener ♠KQ1063 ♥AJ5 ♦7 ♣AK84 (17).

Opener	Responder
1♠	1NT
2♣	2♦
Pass	

With 8 HCP responder can't bid 2♦ at once: that would force to game. 1NT first, then 2♦ shows six diamonds and a weak hand, to play.

③ The 2-over-1: game is already forced

Responder ♠K3 ♥A84 ♦AQ1075 ♣Q92 (15). Opener ♠AJ9752 ♥K6 ♦K4 ♣J83 (12).

Opener	Responder
1♠	2♦
2♠	4♠

Opener's 2♠ just shows six spades: no need to jump, game is already forced, and nobody jumps to game on the losers. Responder has two spades and 15: 4♠. With more, either of you could now look for slam slowly.

④ 1♦ – 2♣: game forcing over a minor too

Responder ♠K10 ♥Q4 ♦AJ9 ♣AJ8752 (15). Opener ♠4 ♥KJ8 ♦Q8652 ♣KQ96 (11).

Opener	Responder
1♦	2♣
3♣	3NT

Responder's 2♣ promises game, so opener simply raises clubs with four. No major fit, and responder has something in both majors: 3NT, nine tricks rather than eleven.

Auction so far · Responder · Opener · Convention · Note

Print on A3, or scale to fit A4. Arrows show the order of the auction.